

BRAND OR BANNED!

Are smart branding, advertising and promotional strategies the keys to solve the jigsaw puzzle called recession?



■ SUDESHNA DAS

Those who thought brand management is a luxury—a taboo during a recession—listen to Ravindra Saini, CEO (India) of Aria Telecom Solution. One of the upcoming telecom solutions providers, Aria Telecom ensures its brand presence whether it is recession or not. The recent EFY survey of the Indian electronics industry revealed astute marketers looked at recession as an opportunity rather than a threat. The brave-hearted who invest in brand building during a recession will gain long-term competitive advantage for their brands.

Brands gain value

It has worked for LG. Success came from a deep understanding of their

consumers' needs and desires, continuously introducing innovative products, establishing good management practices and, of course, great brand building. The "Life's Good" slogan along with introduction of eco-friendly technology, led them to a premium position in India.

Sure, the big boys like LG, Sony, Philips and Videocon are spreading their footprints in a systematic manner. What about the SMEs? Agreed, they might not have the sheen of a Tata or Bharti Teletel, but an out-of-the-box approach can often lead to a huge success. So who are the ones taking great leaps of faith? Well, just about everyone.

Starting from small trading houses of Chandni Chowk in Delhi to export-oriented R&D organisations, all are

somehow trying to gain business value from smart branding. This fact was supported by almost 97 per cent of the EFY survey respondents. Companies are also using the strategy of showing the 'human face' of 'Brand India' in order to successfully combat the threat of Chinese products, revealed Ram Mohan, CEO of Accurex Solution—a firm with 15 years of experience in the field of PCB assembly.

Brand isn't just a smart logo or tag line

Despite common belief, none of the surveyed executives considered a brand to be just about a logo, tagline or glossy brochure. Instead, they felt a strong brand integrated multiple components such as customer satisfaction, employee communication, corporate philosophy and advertising/marketing efforts. If these components don't consistently reinforce your brand, it can lead to customer dissatisfaction. This can erode your brand equity

Methodology

To assess the brand awareness as well as importance of branding in defying recession, EFY's research bureau conducted a survey of the Indian electronics industry.

For this survey, 75 companies were randomly selected. This sample is a microcosmic representation of India's electronics industry. Senior executives from these organisations were asked four standard questions regarding:

1. Importance of brand value
2. Importance of brand management
3. Importance of market presence
4. Preferred modes of brand projection

The data obtained was then collated and analysed. The results of the analysis are presented here.